Chapter Thirteen

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The Sleeping Knight

01

CODY

Words are a currency she can't afford when her panic sets her over the edge. She speaks in strings of syllables I can't comprehend, but it's not her desperate cries that confuse me the most.

It's the fact that the last four weeks passed so peacefully. I thought this was all just a dream after that drunken night with Miguel, but the beautiful girl I mistook for a cosplayer chokes on her tears between breaths as she buries her face into my arm.

"They've all abandoned me," she says. "I failed to . . . he almost died, because . . ." My fingers trace her back until I realize I'm just touching her armor (and it's doing nothing for her). I gently guide her back against the couch. For every extra breath of air she finds, she shells it out in useless ramblings that drive her further into a panic, tensioning her body inwards as the tears flow from her face.

She tensions her hands around my arm so strongly that the blood starts seizing in my own limb.

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"Save your breath," I tell her. "You have to breathe. Whatever happened has passed, and it's over now. You're safe here."

"But the town—"

"The town is fine," I tell her, uncertain of what delusion could cause such a visceral reaction. It was all a fever dream, right? I remember getting sliced across the palm, but I woke up without a scratch. The girl's my neighbor: just a whacked-out cosplayer. Maybe someone reported her stream to the IRS for tax evasion?

She finds more words as her trembling subsides. "I only came here because . . . I had no other choice, and as much as I wish I never had to see you again . . ."

"Excuse me?" I ask.

"I mean . . . as much as I know we hate each other, after—"

"— I don't hate you," I tell her. But then the semantics of that lucid dream come back to me. The cut in my palm. The kitchen knives she threw at my head. "Not that much, I mean." And then I remember the gash she sliced in my championship lacrosse stick that got me from freshman benchwarmer to Varsity senior. "I'm just afraid of you. And—and you piss me off a little, but not that much," I say, trying to balance the resurgent feelings of vice with a desire for goodwill.

Her stress slides further from panic into sorrow, exchanging less heaving breaths for more tears. She's dressed entirely in her custom light armor: I'd think she'd only need it above the torso to film a Let's Play in character, but she's committed to the part.

"Hey. Let's get that armor off of you," I tell her. She reaches for the faux-leather straps on the sides, and when I grab the shoulder pads, I find them oddly cold to the touch.

I try lifting as she lifts her arms, but it's pretty heavy for light armor. The fabric feels hand-woven, with the smallest imperfections that tell of old-world craftsmanship. It smells of sweat and manual labor. And as I struggle to pull it off her body, I notice the contours of the breastplate are caught on something beneath.

"Ow," she sniffles. "Let me loosen the straps more."

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"You got this made of actual metal? Cast iron?"

"What else would stop an arrow?" She asks, holding her breath as I tug harder. Once she finds enough breath to go without it, she exhales completely, and in an instant, I lose my balance and trip over one of the unpacked boxes from four weeks ago.

The entire weight of the armored torso lands on my face when I crash to the floor. My hands cup the meager metal chest contours of modified men's armor, weighing against my face and smelling of sweat as if I were stuck in a scrum of lacrosse players.

But I can hear her breathe easier without the burden of all that cosplay gear. Her breathless panic makes even more sense when I rid my face of the breastplate, discovering how much she has to contort herself just to fit into the damn thing.

She removes the last of her bindings, far tighter than the "combat corset" that constrains her waist. She pulls at the fabric of the undershirt to circulate air, where two large sweat spots accentuate the shape of her chest.

Her face and golden eyes alone could get a zoomer to watch her stream Excel spreadsheets: if she ditched the immersive armor and went for something less practical, she could be living in a mansion!

I open my mouth to try to distill that compliment into something platonic, but stop when I see the state of her. Her disheveled hair is frayed far past the braid I first saw her with. Crescents dig beneath her eyes, and as she still works at slowing her breaths — muttering to herself something about "where she is" — I can see how tired this whole ordeal has made her, and my feelings of malice slip away.

She sits with her head in her hands, tensioning her fingers around her scalp. I'd offer her a hug if I didn't think she still hated me, so instead, I decide to warm her with something else.

I approach the kitchen, starting the coffee maker to make some hot chocolate my mom left from the old house. I watch her golden eyes peer over the edge of the couch when the heating element starts boiling the water, like my parents' cat when the refrigerator makes ice.

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"It's not Starbucks," I tell her.

She tilts her head. "What is it doing?"

"Boiling water?" I answer.

"Huh." She leans higher, watching the flickering blue LED light with a genuine sense of bewilderment. "So you do have Essence. Why didn't you use it?"

"Essence?" I ask.

"Essence. To run the mechanism: top off the Essence capacitor. Like a stove, or a fan, or..."

"It runs on electricity."

"Electricity?" She asks. "What a waste. How do you have that much power? And how rich are you to have all this," she gestures around the living room, "stuff?"

She still finds the strength to do her bit, despite whatever wore on her. "I bought most of it at Home Goods and that corner part of Ross without the clothes. I'm far from rich when I have a mortgage hanging over my head now," I tell her.

"You must make a lot of Kine off your inventions."

"Not yet. I get paid to modify other people's stuff," I tell her. My hands reach into the cabinet, finding the old matching mugs Kei and I bought for the Student Government club room. I hesitate over which one to grab, then after the coffee maker pings, I grab my own.

The old coffee maker dispenses the succulent store-bought chocolate into the mug, rising with steam as dots of moisture condense on the blue inner walls of the porcelain. But it doesn't feel very warm.

"Oh. It's a drink," she says.

I look at her, puzzled, until she gestures to bring it over.

"It's an old coffee maker from my parents' house. They got a new Keurig, so they let me have the old one — the model before it scanned the damn pods to make sure you're buying theirs. Heating element isn't great, so

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hopefully it's not like drinking chocolate milk."

"Not a problem," she says, taking the cup into her hands. I notice a faint glow emanate from beneath the cup as the air warms around her, and in seconds, the cup is steaming again.

It's my turn for bewilderment. She catches my expression with a tired glance.

"What?"

"How did you...?"

I bend to look beneath the mug, but there's nothing there. Once I realize it looks like I'm staring directly at her breasts, I bend upright.

"What kind of an uncultured bumpkin are you?" She asks. "Life and fire. Humans. You. Me," she says, raising her right hand to pretend she's bending fire.

Pretending, right?

I feel the heat first. And then at a point an inch above her palm, a spark transitions into a raging plume of controlled fire, casting the walls in flickering light.

I instinctively reach to see if it's a hologram. I feel burning heat before she ceases, slapping my hand away.

"You grab for fire like you grabbed for that dagger," she says. "Pray tell, what kind of stupid idiot savant are you?"

I stammer over my words. My mind races through every physics and thermodynamics textbook I've ever skimmed for problem sets, and can't find any explanation. The sudden wave of confusion is so strong that I sit down on the box I tripped on moments earlier. "Sweet Carnot," I say.

"Is that one of your gods?"

"If you design cars and airplanes," I say. "What the fuck?" And then I gesture to her. "Do it again. How did you do that?"

I'm too damn tired, she says.

"Do it," I insist, like a child at a birthday magic show.

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She casts it again as she takes her first sip from the mug, careful to watch if I'll try and reach for it again, but I raise my hands.

Her eyes light with delight. It seems like an emotion she hasn't felt in a long time.

"This is really good," she says. "What is it?"

"Hot chocolate. From the grocery store. But really, though. How did you —"

She takes another loud sip. "I usually hate sweet stuff. But this is nice." She warms it further with her hands: the mug glows with conductive heat, and then she drinks all the rest of it in a single swallow.

Now I have my head in my hands, unsure whether I really want to know the secret behind her sleight-of-hand.

"You really have never seen this before? Even a child can make a spark," she insists, reclining back into the couch as her eyes feather on the edge of exhausted sleep.

"I'm not a damn child," I tell her. "It's not real. You can't just..." but then I realize she's fading away on the couch: it must be comfortable if it makes Miguel fade away this easily, too.

I take the mug by the handle and rinse it in the sink. The red-hot bottom evaporates the first volume of water to steam before it normalizes, and I flip it upside-down into the dish organizer, since I haven't run the dishwasher in a week and I can't remember if it's all dirty or not. On the bottom, I inspect the words I wrote almost a decade earlier.

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She breathes so softly on the couch that I almost forget she's there. And when I approach, I find her deep in sleep: sweating again, muttering something about a cabin as her right hand searches for something.

She mutters a name.

I don't hear it.

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"Stay," she asks, as tears crest again in her eyes, and I sit on the box again, as her hand feels for something like fronds of a flower feeling for the sun, finding its way to mine.

And once it finds me, it refuses to let go.

02

KATIYA

I wake again from dreams of fire. My hand is always first to feel for the other side of the bed, but my fingers are already laced in something.

I long so deeply for something warm to hold. I want the heat to quell my panic, to overwrite the memories and feelings that sensation brings with something warm that's better. The cabin is collapsing again: no windows or doors, just a hot box of logs crumbling under the weight of my father's weakness, and I can feel my own muscles tension further in whatever I can grab to ease the pain.

My eyes feather open to the light of an unfamiliar sun. The birds sound different. The space smells like the industrial quarter of Northaven, and when I feel the sensation of feathers against my neck, I wonder if I squeezed another pillow so hard that the stuffing came out.

But it's the hair of a man. Not my man. But a man that mumbles something with his face buried between my breasts as I tension him further.

When I release him, he gasps, and I notice the spread of blankets on the floor. One of the couch's pillows is on the ground, and a scrounging of scavenged blankets makes a meager bed. His face is flushed with a mix of several dissimilar emotions he can't resolve, and mine flushes further when I realize what I've done.

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"Y-you know how lucky you are that it's a Saturday?" he says. "I could barely reach for enough to make a bed to get a couple hours of sleep! Then pulling me in like that? And I don't even know your name," he says.

"Katiya," I tell him. "Katiya Breakey-Hilde. And you're . . . Cody?"

"Yeah," he says, wiping the sweat from my chest off both sides of his face. "At least I had my phone with me. I ordered us something: you can pay me later."

I look at the laughable spread of blankets and bedsheets again, more concerned about the duress I put him under. "You could have let go. I mean, you don't even know me. Why didn't you force my hand away and get a good night of sleep?"

His voice quiets on a hint of humiliation. "Well, you know, you were crying and all. Said not to leave, again and again, and your grip is pretty strong, so..."

"So you didn't leave," I say. Something makes me want to tear up again when a strange sense of relief approaches, but I'm done being weak and sentimental. "Well, thank you."

"Sure. But you can do me a favor and take a shower?" he asks.

"Excuse me?" I ask.

"It smells like you haven't showered in a week," he says.

"I can't afford a shower," I tell him. "I went in the lake last week, then took a bath, like, four days ago."

"Really? You can afford to shower. It's not like the drought three years ago."

"Can't afford A SHOWER," I clarify, gathering my things like a mistress of the night.

"It comes with the damn unit!" Cody exclaims. "How could you possibly not have a shower? There were only two options in the builder's package. Either Mantequilla, or—"

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"Wait," I say, putting my hand to his mouth. A shadow approaches the door of his house that's so immaculate and messy at the same time. "Did you hear that?"

"Probably just the delivery driver," I say.

"That's not a knocker." I reach for the knife I kept hidden in the side holster of my breastplate, ready to pounce as soon as the adversary blasts open the door. Cody is too weak to defend himself.

"Yo, chill! Chill out. Look," he says, showing me a brightly-lit device with far more little colored squares than the music box. A cartoon of an automobile is on the screen, dancing around the center of a map. "You don't have to stab first and ask questions later, soldier girl."

"And you don't have to grab fire and blades, foolish boy," I respond.

He cracks the door. I rise to my feet and find the footing to attack, but when the door opens, some bearded guy with earrings and fancy glasses hands a bag to him. Cody mutters some question about whether the tip of something is in an app, and then he nods, allowing him to close the door, and when I catch a glimpse of the scene beyond the door, I realize again that it looks nothing like Gaffesend.

I rush to the window, throwing open the shades. "Where is this? Where are you? And where's the lake?" I ask. I begin to think it's all a ruse to trap me at my weakest.

"A couple blocks down. You think I could afford lakeside in this economy?" He asks. "But the walk is nice."

Before he can hand me something from the bag, I race back across the threshold of my door, only to find my world the same way I left it. From my window, Gaffesend is abuzz with the week's end sight of commoners strolling on the cobblestone streets.

"Katiya," Cody calls. "Do you want your tacos or not?"

"Cody," I say. "This is..."

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He crosses the threshold of the door, finding the same sight he must have thought was just a dream. Now he rushes to my window, watching the water reflect in the light of an early-morning sun.

I'm glad he put the bag down in the other world. He clutches his chest, short of breath, and I think the man of science is finally beginning to understand that the world is not as measurable as he thinks.

His face flushes white as if he's seen a Chymaeran fleshwalker. I have to catch him before he falls, and I grab him by the space between his arms.

"You weren't — you mean that—" Cody tries to struggle from my grasp to walk out my front door for the first time by his own volition, but his clothes are far too strange: they might think he's a Chymaeran spy, or ask his noble heritage.

"Stop resisting," I command, hugging him to my chest. I realize I'm speaking my own tongue now, and he's speaking mine, and I say, "seriously, can you stop fighting me when I'm trying to help you?"

"Do it again," he says, slumping in dead weight before he collects himself, rising to his feet half a head taller than me. "Do the fire trick again."

I roll my eyes. "It's not a trick, Cody."

"Do it," he says, then adds, "please," staring at me with his dark brown eyes.

I light a simple flame. He looks on with such stupid, childlike captivation that I wonder what other dumb banality could capture his attention.

"Holy shit," he says. "And how do you do that?"

"Watch this," I say.

I direct the energy to form a loop of flame, spinning around my palm. And some of the other stupid tricks the cadets used to come up with. "So can we eat now?"

"I guess it will never get cold," he says.

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"So you live your whole life without Essence?" I ask him. "So you're some kind of purist monk?"

He responds in my tongue again without noticing he's doing it. "No Essence at all. Just electricity: there's no magic in our world."

"But what about the cars?" I ask.

"A four-stroke engine that runs on dead dinosaurs." I don't catch the meaning of the last word, but my mind associates it with creatures from an eternity ago. He clarifies. "Gasoline. Hydrocarbons from crude oil."

"It's as if the world wasn't made for you. As if your world never had the blessings of the Gods."

"We don't know if there is a god, beyond money and power," Cody says. "They certainly haven't introduced themselves in person."

"Well, let's eat," I insist. "Before it gets cold, or before I have to warm it up again."

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